Lesson 3 — The Night the Network Failed

Part 5 of 12: The sounds of was and were

Level: A2 (third step)

About 20 minutes · this part carries a sheet and audio

3.3 The two sounds of was and were (listen to `05-weak-forms.mp3`)

In a sentence, was and were are almost always weak — short and quiet. They are strong only at the end of a sentence, or when we want to insist that something is true.

WORD	WEAK (NORMAL, INSIDE A SENTENCE)	STRONG (AT THE END, OR TO INSIST)
was	/wəz/	/wɒz/
were	/wə/	/wɜː/

WEAK	STRONG
He was working at his desk.	Yes, he was.
The room was quiet.	It was.
Three students were working near the window.	Yes, they were.
The lights were low.	They were.

In the audio you hear each pair twice, then a short test: say whether the was or were you hear is weak or strong, then listen to the answer.